mathematics (among others). Students pursuing an academic degree must usually decide to which of these departments they belong. Their decision limits their choice of courses, which in turn shapes their understanding of the world. Mathematics students learn how to predict future morbidity levels from present rates of infection; biology students learn how viruses mutate over time; and history students learn how religious and political beliefs affect people's willingness to follow government instructions. To fully understand COVID-19 requires taking into account mathematical, biological and historical phenomena, but academic bureaucracy doesn't encourage such a holistic approach.

As you climb the academic ladder, the pressure to specialise only increases. The academic world is ruled by the law of publish or perish. If you want a job, you must publish in peer-reviewed journals. But journals are divided by discipline, and publishing an article on virus mutations in a biology journal demands following different conventions from publishing an article on the politics of pandemics in a history journal. There are different jargons, different citation rules and different expectations. Historians should have a deep understanding of culture and know how to read and interpret historical documents. Biologists should have a deep understanding of evolution and know how to read and interpret DNA molecules. Things that fall in between categories – like the interplay between human political ideologies and virus evolution – are often left unaddressed.[20]

To appreciate how academics force a messy and fluid world into rigid bureaucratic categories, let's dig a little deeper in the specific discipline of biology. Before Darwin could explain the origin of species, earlier scholars like Carl Linnaeus first had to define what a species is and classify all living organisms into species. To argue that lions and tigers evolved from a common feline ancestor, you first have to define 'lions' and 'tigers'.[21] This turned out to be a difficult and never-ending job, because animals, plants and other organisms often trespass the boundaries of their allotted drawers.

Evolution cannot be easily contained in any bureaucratic schema. The whole point of evolution is that species continually change, which means that putting each species in one unchanging drawer distorts biological reality. For example, it is an open question when *Homo erectus* ended and *Homo sapiens* began. Were there once two Erectus parents whose child was the first Sapiens?[22] Species also keep intermingling, with animals